Volibear & The Ursine of Freljord

by @ashenbolt
BoltNine Homebrew

Art by KD Stanton

Ursine

Isso lowered his snout to the base of the tree, *sniffing the wet bark. His nostrils flared as he inhaled deeply. Satisfied, he stood, a grin appearing as he looked in the direction of his prey. Isso began to run, initially on his hind legs but switching to all fours as he sped up. His grin turned into a snarl as he charged towards his target.*

His momentum was broken as he ran directly into a river, drenching him before he could stop. Snarling, Isso stood, looking around to reclaim the scent he was following. Unable to find it, he slapped the flowing water with large paws, sending a booming sound echoing through the trees. Isso returned to shore and began looking around for a new sign of his prey.

Tales of Isso Brownbark

Nestled at the base of a large mountain range, the Ursine village lies at the edge of an ever-present maelstrom, the Gelid Vortex, which hovers just beyond the protective rim of mountains. Battling through frigid winters, the Ursine are a hardy race with centuries of tradition to call back upon.

Animalistic

Though many see the Ursine as intelligent bears, there are many differences between the Ursine and their savage cousin. A fully grown Ursine is much smaller than a bear and is as nimble on his hind legs as he is on all four. Outsiders may find it hard to believe, but the rough Ursine have much more restrain and self-control than the beasts they are often mistaken for, though some suspect this is a result of their lack of need to hibernate.

Strong and Tough

Years of living in the rough northern lands of the Freljord have made the Ursine tough. The harsh winters at the base of a mountain range often lead to lack of food, requiring many of the Ursine to survive off of the tough plant life native to the Freljord. Though many of the other races have trouble with the low temperatures of the north, the Ursine are barely affected by the cold, instead kept warm by their fur coats.

Homeland Traditions

Many Ursine choose to wander the world in their formative years, curious about the state of the rest of the world. However, most of which who go out often return to their home, either because they miss their home or their curiosity has been sated.

As a result of the journeying many Ursine do, the age-old traditions of the Ursine are an eclectic mix, with bits and pieces taken from the other cultures of the land.

History of War

In the past, long ago, the Ursine were a warrior race, savage, fierce, and disciplined. However, once peace arrived at Freljord, the Ursine settled down and much of their war-like temperament was lost.

This changed once Volibear, the town shaman, had visions of a brutul conflict. Journeying to the top of the mountain, he was touched by an unnatural bolt of lightning. Journeying to his village, he roused his people and began returning them to the state of their fore-fathers, proud warriors.

Ursine Names

Ursine name their young based on what they want them to achieve as adults. An aggressive, war-like Ursine may give his son a rough, cacophonous name while another might name her son after the hero of an Ursine folk tale.

Male Ursine Names: Arrus, Anrun, Callun, Deruhs, Leneth, Marukus, Olland, Rutushush, Veeros, Wlaren

Female Ursine Names: Arsa, Belara, Dalara, Edulla, Hoinda, Ollinde, Nacura, Neruna, Warra

Ursine Traits

Ursine have racial traits common with a common bear ancestry and some unique to the Ursine people.

Ability Score Increase. Your Strength score increases by 1 and your Constitution score increases by 2.

Age. Ursine mature quicker than humans, reaching adulthood around age 16. Despite this, they live as long as humans.

Alignment. Most Ursine follow a personal code. Because of this, many Ursine are lawful, thought it may not seem as such if the law of the land conflicts with their person code. Many Ursine are kind, though their value their race's well-being above that of outsiders.

Size. Ursine are larger than humans in both height and width. Their range from 5 and a half feet to 7 feet tall. Your size is Medium.

Speed. Your base walking speed is 25 feet if you walk on your hind legs and 35 feet if you are walking on all four.

Natural Armor. Your hide acts as natural armor. You have a natural armor bonus of +1. When unarmored, your AC is equal to 1 + your natural armor bonus + your Dexterity modifier.

Art by sandara

Bite. You are proficient with your bite, which deals 1d4 piercing damage. If you have grappled a creature, you may use your bonus action to bite them.

Claws. You are proficient with your unarmed strikes, which deal 1d4 slashing damage.

Languages. You can speak, read, and write Common and Ursine. Not many people know Ursine, as it is a difficult language for outsides to learn. Though the language sounds harsh, it is capable of expressing beautiful sentiments.

Monastic Traditions

There are many monasteries scattered across the lands. Each specializes in a different school of thought. Many study the basic three, but there are others, sitting far from society, with other specialties.

Way of the Thundering Claw

Monks who master the Way of the Thundering Claw have travelled to the base of the Gelid Vortex's mountains and studied with the Ursine in their village. Those who dedicate them to this tradition learn the ferocity of the bear, channeling nature's savagery with every hit.

Swipe of the Claw

At 3rd level, you have learned how make your attacks more ferocious. As a bonus action, you can spend 1 ki points to have your next unarmed strike deal an additional 1d4 slashing damage and force the targeted creature to make a Constitution saving throw or be inflicted with the ***Savage Wounds*** debuff. The saving throw DC for this effect is equal to 8 + your Wisdom modifier + your proficiency bonus. This damage scales with your martial arts ability.

Savage Wounds. A creature afflicted with Savage Wounds bleeds for an additional 1d4 damage at the beginning of each of their turns for 2 rounds. They can expend a bonus action to end the effect by rolling a Medicine check against your Savage Wounds DC. This damage scales with your martial arts ability.

Fortitute of the Bear

At 6th level, you can use your ki to channel the power and durability of the bear. As an action, you can spend 2 ki points to increase your Constitution score by 2, up to 22, and gain advantage on all Strength (Athletics) and grapple checks for up to 1 minute.

Predator

Beginning at 11th level, you have advantage on Charisma (Intimidation) checks and Wisdom (Perception) checks which rely on smell.

In addition, if you attack a creature who has ***Savage Wounds***, you extend the duration of the debuff by 1 round. This effect can only occur once per turn per targeted creature.

Ripping Blows

At 16th level, you know how to pressure a wounded target. You have advantage on all targets with the ***Savage Wounds*** debuff. Also, if you land an attack against a creature with the ***Savage Wounds*** debuff, you can spend 1 ki point to remove the debuff and instantly dealing 3d8 additional damage on your attack.

Art by Yamo Orce

The Ursine of Freljord

The central inhabitance of ursine in the north is the Ursine Village, a medium-sized village at the base of the Gelid Vortex Mountain. The ursine, who were once a war-like and fierce race, have become tranquil as they prospered. Fearing that the ursine had become weak, their leader Volibear strives endlessly to return the once fearsome race to greatness.

Volibear

Volibear was once the village mystic, advising the village leaders, the triumvirate. However, Volibear felt unease as he saw his fellow ursine grew softer, forgetting their battle-hardened traditions.

Journey to the Mountaintop. Having been turned away by the triumvirate, Volibear decided to journey to the top of the ursine's sacred mountain. The journey was difficult, for the mountain is surrounded by a never-ending maelstrom. Volibear journeyed onwards, hoping to find his answer at the top.

The Thunder's Roar. Once at the top, Volibear was struck by a bolt of electricity which gave him visions of terrible things to come if the ursine were not roused. With new power, he journeyed back to his village.

The True Chieftain. Once he returned to the bottom, Volibear challenged the triumvirate for control of the village, citing his visions as a need for change. After a fierce and bloody battle, the triumvirate conceded, naming Volibear the sole chieftain of the village.

Volibear

Medium beast (ursine), chaotic good

Armor Class 17 (half plate)
Hit Points 152 (16d8 + 80)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	14 (+2)	20 (+5)	10 (+0)	18 (+4)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws Con +8
Skills Perception +7, Survival +7
Senses passive Perception 17
Languages Common, Ursine
Challenge 8 (3900 XP)

Keen Smell. Volibear has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on smell.

Frenzy. If Volibear lands both claw attacks on the same target, his bite attack will deal an additional 5 (1d8)damage to the target.

Chosen Of The Storm (1/Day). If Volibear falls below 20 hit points, he begins to heal 11 (1d8 + 6) health per round for 5 rounds.

Actions

Multiattack. Volibear can make two attacks with his claws and one attack with his bite.

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d8+3) slashing damage plus 5 (1d8) lightning damage.

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 10 (2d6+3) piercing damage.

Majestic Roar (Recharges After A Short Or Long Rest. Volibear lets out a savage roar, frightening all nearby creatures. All enemies within 30 feet of Volibear must make a DC 15 Wisdom saving throw or be rooted in place for 1 round. On a successful save, all target creatures only have half movement on their next turn.

Ursine Villager

Medium beast (ursine), any alignment

Armor Class 12 (natural armor)
Hit Points 11 (2d8 + 2)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
12 (+1)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	8 (-1)	9 (-1)	10 (+0)

Senses passive Perception 9
Languages Common, Ursine
Challenge 1/8 (25 XP)

Keen Smell. The ursine has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on smell.

Actions

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d8+1) slashing damage.

Ursine Monk

Medium beast (ursine), chaotic good

Armor Class 13 (unarmored defense)
Hit Points 62 (10d8 + 20)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	14 (+2)	9 (-1)

Skills Perception +4, Survival +4
Senses passive Perception 14
Languages Common, Ursine
Challenge 1 (200 XP)

Keen Smell. The ursine monk has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on smell.

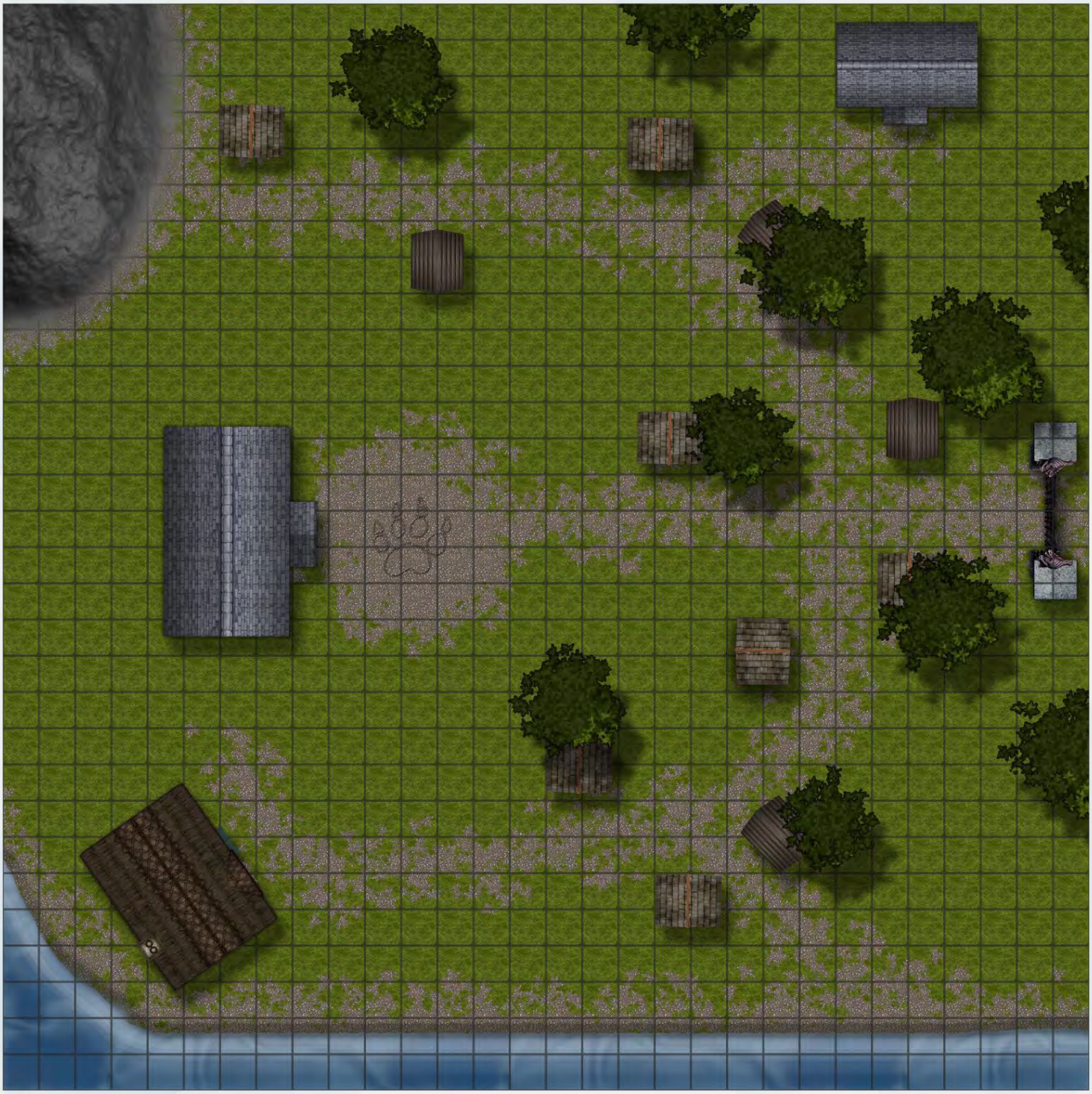
Unarmored Defense. While the ursine monk is wearing no armor and not wielding a shield, his AC includes his Wisdom modifier.

Actions

Multiattack. The ursine monk can make two attack with his claws.

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d8+2) slashing damage plus 2 (1d4) lightning damage.

A Map of the Ursine Village

Below you will find a tiled map of the Ursine village. An impressive stone-columned gate marks the entrance to a large, sweeping area. Most houses are small and built near trees, which help keep snow off the roofs. In the top left corner you can see the edge of the mountains which separate the village from the Gelid Vortex.

In the bottom left, you can see the monastery, where disciples study the arts of wars brought down by their ancestors. Directly besides the clearing is the house of the triumvirate, the body of ursine who govern the village. Ever since Volibear became chief, he has opened the large house to others, citing that he plans on spending more time out than in the stuffy house.